

Cat & Company

Parasocial

8 pp

David White

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Page 1

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Nighttime exterior shot of the Skraggs' house. An upper floor room is illuminated by dim light which is visible through the window.

Penny Skragg (*from inside room*)

What the hell!?

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg sits in front of a large flat screen monitor, keyboard, and mouse. She clicks on a link. The room is dark, but the light from the monitor illuminate **Penny Skragg's** face.

SF/X

click

Penny Skragg

Haven't heard from *him* in *years*...

Panel 3 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A view of Penny's screen. She is watching a video that has been recorded in portrait format. Next to the video player is a partially visible chat window. The video shows an attractive young man in casual clothes, **Dylan Whateley**, who is filming himself in a well-lit interior.

Dylan Whateley

Hey guys! It's *me*, Dylan!

Chat window (*partially visible*)

OpportunityKnockers469: WORK FROM HOME \$40/hr DETAILS HERE: <https://...>

Panel 4 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A view like Panel 3. **Dylan Whateley** holds his phone camera at arm's length, filming himself and the interior of the house he's in. The room he is in appears to be a fairly standard kitchen. He is standing in front of a wooden interior door that looks like it would open to a closet, or perhaps a staircase to a basement.

Dylan Whateley

So, check *this* out.

Looks *normal*, right?

Chat window (*partially visible*)

BlackSun4235: DICKFORCE σ puts the "VRIL" in "VIRILITY"! Only \$299.99/mo! BUY NOW <https://...>

Panel 5 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A view like Panel 3. **Dylan Whateley** opens the door. On the video stream, the door opens to what appears to be a wall of digital encoding errors, with a side order of the old Doom engine's "Hall of Mirrors" effect.

Dylan Whateley

I don't know what this *looks* like—
—but it's a *solid wall* of *nothing*.

Chat window (*partially visible*)

CherylLignam: Eww lame Backrooms slop...

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

Penny Skragg is illuminated by her screen in her dark room. She looks worried.

Dylan Whateley (from monitor speakers)

So let's go *outside*.

It's all messed up *there*, too.

Panel 7 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

Jinx Bubastis approaches the doorway leading to the room **Penny Skragg** is in. **Penny Skragg** gestures for her to come in and watch the stream with her.

Dylan Whateley (from monitor speakers)

It's like the *neighborhood* I grew up in, but the *streets* don't go anywhere.

Penny Skragg

Hey, Jinx!

Have a *look* at this.

Jinx Bubastis

Hmm?

Page 2

Panel 1 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view of Penny's screen, like Panels 3-5 of Page 1. **Dylan Whateley** is outside at night, standing in front of the entrance to a supermarket.

Dylan Whateley

So far, these *doors* are always *unlocked*.

Chat window (partially visible)

Kobi999: AI AI AI AI AI AI

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view like Panels 3-5 of Page 1. **Dylan Whateley** walks into the supermarket. No one is manning the cash registers, but the lights are all on.

Dylan Whateley

Hey! *Anybody* there?

Chat window (partially visible)

Kobi999: AI AI AI AI AI AI

CherylLignam: What a waste of tokens...

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view like Panels 3-5 of Page 1. **Dylan Whateley** looks at a display of boxes of chocolate chip cookies in a brown cardboard box. (Similar to but simpler than this → <https://thefreihofers.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/freihofers-bread-22.jpg>)

Dylan Whateley

Hey, they still *sell* these?

I haven't seen them since I was a *kid*!

Panel 4 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis stands behind **Penny Skragg**, and is looking at the screen carefully. She is propping herself up with her left arm. **Penny Skragg** types something into the keyboard.

Jinx Bubastis

How do you *know* this guy?

Penny Skragg

I used to buy *mids* off him.

Jinx Bubastis

Does the *chat* work?

Penny Skragg

I'll *try* writing to him.

Title

Parasocial

Panel 5 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view like Panels 3-5 of Page 1. **Dylan Whateley** looks at his phone with obvious surprise.

Dylan Whateley

Whoa!

Hey, *cool!* Shout-out to *Penny* in the chat.

Panel 6 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view like Panels 3-5 of Page 1. **Dylan Whateley** talks directly into the camera of his phone. He looks worried.

Dylan Whateley

So, she's asking how I'm doing...

Panel 7 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view like Panels 3-5 of Page 1. **Dylan Whateley** continues talking into the camera in close-up. His expression transitions from worried to lightly scared.

Dylan Whateley

...I don't know *what* to say.

I feel... *lost*.

Page 3

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close-to-mid view from the front of **Penny Skragg** and **Jinx Bubastis** looking intently at the screen of the computer. **Penny Skragg** cocks an eyebrow. **Jinx Bubastis** stands to the left (right side of panel) and scratches her chin.

Penny Skragg

Dylan just *stopped* streaming.
I think that *freaked him out* a little.

Jinx Bubastis

Does he have any *other videos* online?

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view from the side. **Peter Cat** and **Camillo Skragg** are standing unobtrusively behind **Jinx Bubastis** and **Penny Skragg** are the focus and are still concentrating on the screen.

Penny Skragg

He had some *urban exploration* videos up, but they're *years old*.
Where do *you* think he *is*?

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height, no border):

A diagram, loosely based on the central column of the Tree of Life (reference → <https://i.ebayimg.com/images/g/l7UAAOSw6Spe6gw11200.jpg>). “Kether” is a brilliant light shining through a curtain, Tephareth is a raging inferno labelled “Lake of Fire”, Yesod is a sphere of ash labelled “World of Ash”, Malkuth is a portal into the everyday world. The focus is fairly clearly on Yesod.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis gestures subtly towards the diagram in Panel 3 as she tries to explain what she meant.

Jinx Bubastis

Beneath the *Lake of Fire* is a *World of Ash*.
After *contradictions burn away*, shared memories, background details, and *liminal spaces* are left *behind*.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis is standing up. **Penny Skragg** swivels over to look at her. **Peter Cat** and **Camillo Skragg** stand on the other side.

Jinx Bubastis

It forms the *borderlands* between the *living world* and the *realm of the dead*.

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg looks at **Jinx Bubastis**. **Jinx Bubastis** closes her eyes and rubs the side of her head.

Penny Skragg

So, he's *dead*?

Jinx Bubastis

Dead and *unaware of it*.
Yes.

Page 4

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Mid shot of **Camillo Skragg** and **Jinx Bubastis**. **Camillo Skragg** has a thoughtful expression. **Jinx Bubastis** looks at him and smiles a little.

Camillo Skragg

That's an *extraordinary claim*, Jinx.

Jinx Bubastis

True.

But *provable* with *ordinary evidence*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg sits down at the computer. **Penny Skragg** takes the place behind and to the left of the chair where **Jinx Bubastis** was. **Jinx Bubastis** and **Peter Cat** watch just off to the left, and may not be visible on panel.

Camillo Skragg

Didn't Dylan live in *Kingston*?

Let me *call* the *police department*.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

From left to right – the computer, **Camillo Skragg**, **Jinx Bubastis** close behind, and **Peter Cat** and **Penny Skragg** on the right. **Penny Skragg** whispers to **Peter Cat**.

Detective (over monitor speakers)

Ah! Mr. *Skragg* –

– to *what* do we owe the *honor*?

Camillo Skragg

The *honor*?

Detective (over monitor speakers)

We got a *bulletin* about you guys, you're *Federal law enforcement*.

Camillo Skragg

Oh!

It's nothing *serious*, just a *wellness check*.

Penny Skragg (whispering)

We're *Feds*?

Peter Cat

Ssh.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg smiles and does his best to be friendly.

Camillo Skragg

One "Dylan Whateley" – could you have someone check up on him?

Detective (over monitor speakers)

Dylan Whateley?

Let me look.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view of the screen of the computer. The **Detective** looks a little concerned.

Detective (over monitor speakers)

Oh, man. You'll want to contact the *Ulster County Sheriff*.

There's a *missing persons*' investigation running for *years* now.

Page 5

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Exterior, early evening. **Peter Cat**, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg** are in the yard in front of an abandoned mansion (not visible on-panel yet). **Peter Cat** stands in the middle, squinting a little as he scans the surroundings. **Jinx Bubastis** stands next to him, arms crossed. **Camillo Skragg** is sitting on a picnic blanket on the grass and operating a laptop and a software-defined radio rig. **Penny Skragg** crouches behind him, looking into her smartphone.

Peter Cat

So, *this* is the *place*?

Penny Skragg

Yeah.

His last *urban exploration videos* were set here.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view of the group from the rear. They are all facing a decaying mansion.

Penny Skragg

This *abandoned mansion* belonged to an *eccentric billionaire*.

Dylan's *stream* should be starting *shortly*.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis bends over behind **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** as he gets his radio rig ready.

Camillo Skragg

So, how does a *ghost* have *internet*?

Jinx Bubastis

The *World of Ash* can *interact* with *reality*.

Camillo Skragg

I guess a *radio signal* isn't that much different from a *cold spot* or *tossing around small objects* in terms of *energy*.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg looks down at her phone. **Camillo Skragg** is surprised by what his laptop's SDR program is showing him.

Penny Skragg

His *stream* is *starting*...

Camillo Skragg

...and there's the *signal*.

Astonishing.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis stands next to **Peter Cat**.

Peter Cat

There's a *cavern* beneath the *mansion's basement*.

I can *feel* the *signal* from down there.

Jinx Bubastis

Then I will enter *the World of Ash* and try to find *Dylan*.

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Close-up on **Jinx Bubastis**, who looks mildly amused.

Jinx Bubastis

The *stream* will be his *subjective perception* of events.
I imagine I'll have to put the "psycho" in "*psychopomp*".

Page 6

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat passes through the limestone ceiling of the cavern beneath the mansion. His body seems to be reconstituting itself from a smoky form – compare Issue 1, Page 13, Panel 3. In one hand, he holds a ball of light, the only source of illumination in the cave. In the background, a metal staircase leads down to the floor of the cave.

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

As I suspected, the *previous owner* had excavated a cavern beneath his *mansion*.

Box (narration, Sheriff)

Like a *panic room*, or a *bomb shelter*?

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

Something like that.

Construction seems to have *stalled*.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat aims his hand, a little like a flashlight, into the darkness of the cavern. Stalactites hang from the ceiling. There is a large pool of murky water filling much of the cavern.

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

The cavern was carved into *carbonate rock*–

–I believe you call it *limestone*.

Groundwater seeped up *through* the *porous* rock.

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

In the foreground, the skeletal remains of **Dylan Whateley** lie on the floor of the cavern, illuminated by a beam from a ball of light hovering just behind **Peter Cat's** right shoulder. Shreds of his clothing remain. **Peter Cat** is only visible in silhouette in the background.

Box (narration, Sheriff)

And that's *where* you *found* the corpse?

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

Precisely.

I haven't been able to *identify* the deceased, of course.

Box (narration, Sheriff)

That's *our* job, but I'm *pretty sure* that's *Dylan*.

What *happened* to him?

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat carries the corpse of **Dylan Whateley** in his arms, and looks back at the murky water inside the cave.

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

I mentioned *carbonate rocks* and *flooding*.

The *pool of water* was *saturated* with *carbon dioxide*.

Even a *few grains of dust* falling into the water could have *triggered* an *instant release* of *gas*.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat flies through the ceiling of the cavern, leaving a smoky trail, as the ball of light fades.

Box (narration, Sheriff)

Asphyxiation.

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

*The low partial pressure of oxygen would have swiftly led to unconsciousness.
He never had a chance.*

Page 7

All panels on this page use the “screen view” conventions from earlier.

Panel 1 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close-up of **Dylan Whateley**’s eye – a reference to a similar scene towards the end of “The Blair Witch Project.”

Dylan Whateley

ok– ok–
I found a *hiding place*–
that *thing*–
that *thing* won’t get me...

Chat window (partially visible)

Kobi99: The thing’s gonna get him.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The stream shows an out-of-focus patch of light.

Dylan Whateley (not visible)

NO!

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The stream goes dark, as if **Dylan Whateley**’s phone has fallen with its camera pointing at the ground.

Dylan Whateley (not visible)

...no...

Chat window (partially visible)

RM-FR: Someone got got

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The icy-blue, feline eye of **The Entity** fills the stream window. She is propping up **Dylan Whateley**’s phone, so the camera can capture his final moments for the stream.

The Entity (growls)

theRRRRRe...

Panel 5 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Entity walks away from the propped-up phone towards **Dylan Whateley**, who tries unsuccessfully to stand up or crawl away on the basalt surface at the edge of **The Lake of Fire**.

Dylan Whateley

Oh God!
Oh God!
Please help!

The Entity (growls)

...toOOo laAATe...

Panel 6 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Entity grabs **Dylan Whateley** by his collar in one hand, by his belt in the other. She is winding up to throw him high into the air.

Dylan Whateley (screaming)

No!

No!

PLEASE!

Panel 7 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Dylan Whately flies in a parabolic arc high above the **Lake of Fire**, head down, butt up.

Dylan Whateley (screaming)

AAAAAAA!!!

SF/X

yeet

Panel 8 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Dylan Whateley hits the surface of the **Lake of Fire**, and disappears in a flash of flame.

SF/X

pomf

Chat window (partially visible)

Kobi999: K. that's pretty metal.

Panel 9 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The stream suddenly ends, going dark.

Chat window (partially visible)

BumFighter32: F

RM-FR: F

BusterNud12: F

CherylLignam: F

Page 8

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

A cemetery. **Dylan's mom** and **Dylan's dad** stand beside his grave site. The coffin has been lowered into the grave. **Dylan's dad** has placed his arm around **Dylan's mom** in a comforting gesture. In the background, from left to right, stand the **Sheriff**, **Peter Cat**, **Camillo Skragg**, **Penny Skragg**, and **Jinx Bubastis**. All are wearing formal black clothing, except for the **Sheriff** in his police uniform, and **Jinx Bubastis** in a red outfit.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Sheriff** turns to talk quietly to **Peter Cat**. **Peter Cat** nods in acknowledgement of what the **Sheriff** tells him.

Sheriff

You guys *did good*.
Dylan's *folks* needed *closure*.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg whispers to **Jinx Bubastis**.

Penny Skragg

Are his *videos* still *online*?

Jinx Bubastis

The *streaming service* was quite *cooperative* about *taking them down*.
...though I *did* save a *copy* of that *last one*.

Panel 4 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view upwards from **Dylan Whateley's* grave. His parents look down into the grave. They are obviously bereaved, but also visibly relieved.

Box (lower right)

FIN